Endives & Blue Cheese Salad

FROM NELL'S KITCHEN

This is one of my favourite salads to serve when hosting. It's quick to prepare and works beautifully alongside so many menus.

Serves 6 · Prep 20 min · Cook 5 min

INGREDIENTS

FOR THE SALAD

- 5 medium endives
- 2 Granny Smith apples
- 6 large soft dates, pitted and chopped

FOR THE CARAMELIZED PECANS

- 75 g pecan halves
- 2 tbsp caster sugar
- 1 tsp water

FOR THE BLUE CHEESE DRESSING

- 200 g Stilton or Roquefort
- 3 tbsp extra-virgin olive oil
- 3tbsp white balsamic vinegar or apple cider vinegar
- 2 tbsp honey, plus more to taste, especially if using Roquefort
- 3 tbsp crème fraîche
- Salt and freshly ground black pepper, to taste

METHOD

1. Caramelize the pecans. Line a plate or tray with baking paper. Place the sugar and water in a small non-stick frying pan over medium heat. Allow the sugar to dissolve and turn a light amber colour, gently swirling the pan as needed. Add the pecans and stir quickly to coat.
2. Transfer the pecans to the baking paper, separating them with two forks. Leave to cool completely, then roughly chop.
3. Prepare the salad. Trim the bases of the endives and remove any damaged outer leaves. Separate the leaves, rinse if needed and dry thoroughly. Cut into bite-sized pieces.
4. Blend the dressing. Place the blue cheese, olive oil, vinegar, honey and crème fraîche in a blender. Blend until smooth and creamy. Taste and season with pepper and a little salt if needed. If using Roquefort, add a little extra honey to balance its stronger flavour.
5. Core the apples and thinly slice them, leaving the skin on. Place in a large bowl with the endives.
6. Add the dressing and toss until the endives and apples are evenly coated.
7. Transfer to a serving dish. Scatter the caramelized pecans and chopped dates over the top and serve immediately.

Tip

The cheese goes into the dressing. Blend it until smooth so its flavour coats every bite.